

DETAILED ARTICLE PLAN

Free Speech on Campus

For The Daily Gamecock Monthly Magazine

Target: 1,200–1,400 words

1 HEADLINE OPTIONS (Short & Clickable)

1.1 Recommended

Nobody at USC Actually Believes in Free Speech

1.2 Alternatives

- The Free Speech Fraud at USC
- Free Speech for Me, Not for Thee
- USC’s Free Speech Problem Isn’t What You Think
- Both Sides Are Lying About Free Speech
- The Free Speech Hypocrisy No One Will Admit

2 CORE THESIS

*Everyone at USC claims to support free speech, but everyone actually supports free speech **for their side**. Conservative students demand platforms for provocative speakers while supporting state legislation restricting what professors can teach. Progressive students advocate for “deplatforming” while demanding their own protests remain protected. USC administrators mouth neutrality while making content-based decisions about security funding. The honest position is that all sides are engaged in political combat over whose speech gets amplified—and pretending otherwise is intellectual cowardice.*

The Argumentative Edge: This piece doesn’t take a side in the culture war—it indicts *everyone* for selective application of principles they claim to hold sacred.

3 ARTICLE STRUCTURE (1,300 words)

3.1 I. Opening Hook (150 words)

Scene: September 18, 2024. Two events happening simultaneously at USC:

- **Russell House:** Milo Yiannopoulos and Gavin McInnes (Proud Boys founder) speak at “Roast of Kamala Harris” to sparse crowd behind barricades
- **Blatt Field:** 1,000+ students attend “Blatt Bonanza” counter-event with free food, dancing, President Amiridis taking selfies

The question: Both sides claimed victory for “free speech.” Uncensored America said they exercised their rights. Counter-programmers said they responded with “more speech, not enforced silence.” But here’s what nobody asked: *Did anyone actually believe in the principle they were invoking, or were they just using it as a weapon?*

3.2 II. The Conservative Hypocrisy (250 words)

Argument: Conservative students demand platforms at USC while supporting state policies that restrict academic speech.

Evidence:

- **Turning Point USA’s Professor Watchlist:** Lists 300+ professors as “Terror Supporters” and “Antifa”—ASU Professor David Boyles was *assaulted* by TPUSA employees
- **Florida’s DeSantis model:** 13 DEI employees fired at UF; 36 professors (1/3 of faculty) fled New College after conservative board takeover
- **Texas tenure elimination:** SB 18 eliminates tenure; SB 16 lets students get professors fired for teaching CRT
- **SC’s own legislation:** March 2024 bill prohibiting factoring political stances into hiring passed 84-30

The contradiction: You cannot demand a platform for Myron Gaines to call women “biologically inferior” while supporting laws that fire professors for teaching about systemic racism. That’s not free speech—it’s *your* speech.

Quote to include: “There is no act of censorship that is more explicit than literally banning words.” —PEN America

3.3 III. The Progressive Hypocrisy (250 words)

Argument: Progressive students claim “deplatforming isn’t censorship” while demanding their own protests remain protected.

Evidence:

- **Stanford Law shoutdown (2023):** Students shouted down Judge Kyle Duncan for entire speech; DEI Dean confronted him asking if “the juice is worth the squeeze”; conservative student comfort dropped from 45% to 6%
- **Middlebury attack (2017):** Professor Allison Stanger *hospitalized with concussion* while moderating Charles Murray; she later wrote “I feared for my life”
- **April 2024 USC arrests:** Pro-Palestinian protesters arrested for “breach of peace”—same students who would defend their right to protest
- **27,000-signature petition** to cancel the McInnes/Yiannopoulos event—while simultaneously arguing protest is protected speech

The contradiction: You cannot argue that shouting down speakers is “counter-speech” protected by the First Amendment while also arguing that speakers you dislike shouldn’t be given platforms. Either disruptive response to speech is legitimate or it isn’t.

Quote to include: “The remedy to be applied is more speech, not enforced silence.” —Justice Brandeis, *Whitney v. California* (1927)

3.4 IV. The Administrative Hypocrisy (250 words)

Argument: USC claims viewpoint neutrality while making content-based decisions about which events get resources.

Evidence:

- **Security costs as censorship:** UC Berkeley spent \$836,421 on Ben Shapiro security vs. \$5,000 for Justice Sotomayor. *Forsyth County v. Nationalist Movement* (1992) ruled this unconstitutional: “Listeners’ reaction to speech is not a content-neutral basis for regulation.”
- **DOJ investigation (Sept 2025):** After Charlie Kirk assassination, DOJ received “troubling allegations” that USC told TPUSA and Uncensored America no outdoor events for “controversial speakers”
- **Student Government funding denial:** SG voted to reject Uncensored America’s \$3,600 funding request—a content-based decision
- **The Blatt Bonanza spending:** How much did USC spend on counter-programming vs. what student orgs must pay for security?

The contradiction: President Amiridis says USC follows the Chicago Principles and that “the solution to offensive speech is more speech.” But when “more speech” means 1,000 students at a university-supported counter-event while the controversial speakers address empty rooms behind barricades, the institution has taken a side—it just won’t admit it.

3.5 V. The Data Nobody Wants to Hear (200 words)

FIRE Statistics:

- **1998–2012:** 72% of deplatforming attempts came from the *right* (Cardinal Newman Society targeting “Vagina Monologues,” Obama/Clinton commencement speeches at Catholic colleges)
- **2013–2022:** 70% of attempts came from the *left*
- **2023–present:** Roughly equal from both sides
- **2025:** Government censorship surged—114 incidents involving politicians vs. 102 total from 2000–2024

The uncomfortable truth: Whichever side has institutional power uses it to silence the other. The principle of “free speech” is invoked only when convenient.

USC’s own ranking:

- 2024: Bottom 5 (246 of 251)
- 2025: 34th after adopting Chicago Principles
- 2026: 22nd

Improvement came from *policy reform*, not from either side suddenly believing in the principle.

3.6 VI. What Intellectual Honesty Would Require (200 words)

Two honest positions exist:

1. **Consistent viewpoint neutrality:** USC provides equal institutional support for all legal speech, regardless of content. Security costs are never passed to student organizations. No funding decisions based on speaker ideology. Protest is protected; disruption that prevents speech is not.

2. **Openly acknowledged value judgments:** USC admits it makes content-based decisions about which speech to amplify, and debates those values openly. Counter-programming for hateful speakers is institutional policy. We decide collectively what belongs on our campus.

The worst option: What we have now—pretending to neutrality while taking sides, invoking principles we apply selectively, and calling opponents hypocrites while being hypocrites ourselves.

Call to action: The next time you hear someone invoke “free speech” at USC—whether it’s Uncensored America demanding a platform, protesters demanding a cancellation, or administrators claiming neutrality—ask one question: *Would you apply this principle if the speaker’s politics were reversed?*

If the answer is no, they don’t believe in free speech. They believe in power.

4 KEY DATA POINTS TO INCLUDE

Category	Statistic	Source
USC-Specific		
Blatt Bonanza	1,000+ students attended	Daily Gamecock, Sept 2024
Petition	27,000 signatures to cancel McInnes/Yiannopoulos	Post and Courier, Sept 2024
FIRE Ranking	Bottom 5 (2024) → 22nd (2026)	FIRE College Free Speech Rankings
DOJ Letter	Sept 19, 2025 warning about viewpoint discrimination	Post and Courier
National Trends		
Deplatforming	1,406 attempts since 1998; 39% successful	FIRE Database
Direction Shift	72% from right (1998-2012) → 70% from left (2013-2022) → equal (2023+)	FIRE
Govt Censorship	114 incidents in 2025 vs. 102 total (2000-2024)	FIRE Scholars Under Fire
Heckler’s Veto	3 incidents (2021) → 79 (2024)	FIRE
Student Attitudes		
Shouting Down	40% consider “sometimes” or “always” acceptable	Knight Foundation 2024

Category	Statistic	Source
Violence	33% consider “some-times” or “always” acceptable (up from 20% in 2020)	FIRE
Self-Censorship	66% report self-censoring in classroom	Knight Foundation 2024
Security Costs		
Ben Shapiro	\$836,421 (Berkeley, 2017)	CNN, Berkeleyside
Milo Yiannopoulos	\$800,000 for 15-minute appearance	UC Berkeley
Sonia Sotomayor	\$5,000 (Berkeley, 2011)	YAF lawsuit filing
Legal Standard	<i>Forsyth County</i> (1992): content-based fees unconstitutional	Supreme Court

5 SOURCES TO INTERVIEW

5.1 For Balance (Get Both Sides)

Conservative perspective:

- USC Turning Point USA chapter president
- USC Uncensored America leadership
- Young Americans for Freedom representatives

Progressive perspective:

- Brooklyn Brown (organized “Art of Womanhood” counter-event)
- Q+ Honor Caucus representatives
- USC Students for Justice in Palestine (if active)

Administration:

- USC spokesman Jeff Stensland (on record about DOJ letter)
- Division of Student Affairs on event security policies
- Student Government on funding decisions

5.2 Expert Sources

- **FIRE:** Alex Morey, Director of Campus Rights Advocacy
- **PEN America:** Suzanne Nossel, CEO
- **USC Law School:** Prof. Derek Black (First Amendment)
- **Greg Lukianoff:** FIRE President, author of “The Coddling of the American Mind”

6 KEY QUOTES TO USE

6.1 From Legal Authorities

“Speech cannot be financially burdened, any more than it can be punished or banned, simply because it might offend a hostile mob.”

—*Forsyth County v. Nationalist Movement* (1992)

“The remedy to be applied is more speech, not enforced silence.”

—Justice Louis Brandeis, *Whitney v. California* (1927)

6.2 From USC Administration

“We condemn the vile and juvenile rhetoric used to promote this event... [but] censoring even the most hateful individuals and groups does not solve the problems we face in our society.”

—President Amiridis & Board Chair Westbrook, August 27, 2024

6.3 From Students

“They want that sort of division and debate and argument, and so I’m trying to redirect that into a more positive environment here.”

—Brooklyn Brown, counter-event organizer

“I wanted to oppose the event happening at Russell and didn’t feel safe protesting.”

—Kristen Issa, fourth-year student at Blatt Bonanza

7 URLS & SOURCES

7.1 USC-Specific

- Daily Gamecock Blatt Bonanza coverage: <https://www.dailygamecock.com/article/2024/09/over-1000-students-attend-blatt-bonanza-during-controversial-campus-event-news-grady>
- Post & Courier DOJ investigation: https://www.postandcourier.com/education-lab/usc-doj-charlie-kirk-outdoor-event-controversial/article_c1d6ca0b-1173-403d-bd16-6f8fec66.html
- FIRE USC Spotlight 2025: <https://thefire.org/sites/default/files/2024-09/2025%20CFSR%20Spotlight%20-%20U%20of%20South%20Carolina.pdf>
- USC Presidential Statement: https://sc.edu/about/our_leadership/president/presidential-commun2024-08-27_statement_about_campus_speakers.php

7.2 National Data

- FIRE Deplatforming Database: <https://www.thefire.org/research-learn/campus-deplatforming-dat>
- FIRE “Worst of Both Worlds”: <https://www.thefire.org/news/worst-both-worlds-campus-free-spee>
- Knight Foundation 2024: <https://knightfoundation.org/reports/college-student-views-on-free-e>
- UC Berkeley security costs: <https://www.berkeleyside.org/2018/02/06/uc-berkeley-spent-close-4m>

7.3 Legal

- *Forsyth County v. Nationalist Movement*: <https://supreme.justia.com/cases/federal/us/505/123/>
- PEN America Heckler's Veto: <https://pen.org/what-is-a-hecklers-veto/>
- ACLU Campus Speech: <https://www.aclu.org/documents/speech-campus>

8 EDITORIAL NOTES

8.1 Tone

- **Angry but even-handed:** The piece attacks hypocrisy on all sides, not one side
- **Data-driven:** Let statistics do the arguing
- **Local grounding:** Every national point connects to USC events
- **No false equivalence:** Acknowledge the right currently holds more institutional power, but document the left's censorship record when they had power

8.2 Anticipated Objections

From the right: "You're comparing students shouting to state legislation!"

Response: Both are attempts to silence. The difference is institutional power, not principle.

From the left: "Hate speech isn't free speech!"

Response: Legally, it is (with narrow exceptions). But that's not the point—the point is you invoke "free speech" for your protests while denying it to others.

From administration: "We follow the Chicago Principles!"

Response: Then explain the DOJ letter. Explain why SG can reject funding based on speaker content. Explain Blatt Bonanza's budget vs. security fees for conservative events.

8.3 Visual Suggestions

- Side-by-side photos: Blatt Bonanza crowd vs. barricaded Russell House
- Infographic: Deplatforming attempts by direction over time (1998–2025)
- Pull quote: "Nobody believes in free speech. They believe in power."